

The Cultural Lens



Critique of Literature

Pre-Think-It



1. What is one tradition in your household (and/or with your friends)?
2. How does race contribute to identity?
3. How does nationality contribute to identity?

Stereotypes vs. Reality



- ❧ What are some stereotypes that pervade our society in regard to culture or race or nationality?
- ❧ In response what is the reality that underlies the stereotype?
- ❧ <https://tinyurl.com/zxfp7rdz>



The Literary Lens



- ❧ One way of deriving the more abstract or meaningful points of a piece of literature is to look at specific aspects of the text that reveal something below the surface of the literal story.
- ❧ We refer to these approaches as “Literary Lenses.”
- ❧ Like putting on a pair of colored glasses that makes everything shades of one color, literary lenses make us focus on one aspect of the text to examine.

Merriam Webster: Culture

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- ❧ “a : the customary beliefs, social forms, and material traits of a racial, religious, or social group; *also* : the characteristic features of everyday existence (such as diversions or a way of life) shared by people in a place or time
 - ❧ b : the set of shared attitudes, values, goals, and practices that characterizes an institution or organization
 - ❧ c : the set of values, conventions, or social practices associated with a particular field, activity, or societal characteristic studying the effect of computers on print *culture*
 - ❧ d : the integrated pattern of human knowledge, belief, and behavior that depends upon the capacity for learning and transmitting knowledge to succeeding generations”

The Cultural Lens



- ❧ Just like it sounds, the cultural lens focuses on the nuances of culture
- ❧ This includes (but is not limited to):
 - ❧ Cultural (personal) values
 - ❧ Religious norms and values
 - ❧ Artistic values
 - ❧ Socio Economic Values
 - ❧ Technological values
 - ❧ Gender Norms
 - ❧ Racial perceptions/treatment
 - ❧ Stereotypes

Historical Context



✧ It is vital to consider historical context when examining cultural aspects of a text – what is now extremely racist/unacceptable might have been normal in the time it was written (this doesn't mean it's not racist – just that we judge it differently). As well, what might seem racist/culturally biased in our modern era, might have been progressive in a much more racist/culturally biased era.

Why is this Important?



- ❧ To examine unfamiliar cultures
- ❧ To see how cultures are portrayed by “others”
- ❧ To examine how culture is perpetuated
- ❧ To look at how stereotypes are formed/perpetuated
- ❧ To think about how culture impacts our actions and behaviors
- ❧ To make objective observations and judgements about the values common to a culture

Hegemony



✧ Like our Feminist/Gender lens and our Marxist lens, the cultural lens also examines hegemony. This is the analysis of how the prevailing culture/race/religion/etc. seeks to maintain its status by perpetuating the idea that they are the best/most important/most enlightened subset of the population. By recognizing the hegemony, we can decide if they are right (for each of us) or whether that paradigm need to change.

The “Other”



- ❧ An important way to see cultural biases in a work is to examine those who are depicted as NOT being part of the dominant culture of the work.
- ❧ WE refer to those in a work who are not part of the dominant culture as the “other”
- ❧ By providing a contrast or being treated differently we can see some how cultural values are applied to the “other” or we can see how the “other” is characterized, victimized, valued or ignored.

Questions Cultural Critics ask about Literary Texts



1. What does this literary work add to our tentative understanding of human experience in that particular time and place, including the ways in which individual identity shapes and is shaped by cultural institutions?
2. How does the text promote ideologies that support and/or undermine the prevailing power structures of the time and place in which it was written and/or interpreted?
3. What social forces and institutions are represented in the work, and how do they work for or against those considered or relegated to be “the other” ?

Questions Cultural Critics ask about Literary Texts



4. What does the literary text add to our understanding of the nuances of culture (such as political, scientific, economic, religious, and educational theories), and how does it shape that culture?
5. What does the literary work suggest about the experience of groups of people who have been ignored, under-represented, or misrepresented by traditional history (for example, laborers, prisoners, women, people of color, children and so on)? How does the work describe positions of power and the dynamics of personal and group identity.
6. How does the work relate to/represent the reader's own cultural experience (if relevant) and does it hold true with the reader's worldview?

The Simpsons – Cultural Lens

- ❧ As you watch *The Simpsons* “Welcome to Homerica,” Think about the following questions and write at least a half page response to the show utilizing the cultural lens to analyze the topic of the episode.
- ❧ What cultural differences are emphasized in the episode? What differences are ignored/or set aside.
- ❧ Who is “Othered?”
- ❧ What are the cultural breaking points for the people of Springfield?
- ❧ What American cultural values, cultural prejudices, and cultural stereotypes are being satirized in this episode?

For “Shooting an Elephant”

✧ In a full page, utilize the following questions to examine the text from the Cultural lens:



1. What cultures are represented here and what is the status of each of them?
2. How does the narrator describe his cultural position and what does that mean for the text?
3. How does the narrator depict the cultures he must interact with/between?
4. What symbolism can you see in the image of the elephant gone “must?” what culture might it represent and why?
5. What does the narrator’s action say about his culture? What about the responses of his peers?